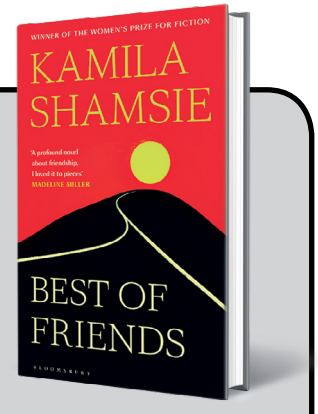
Kamila Shamsie's *Best of Friends* is not just a new novel from a much-awarded third-generation writer. British newspapers are already calling it the 'Book of the Year', and it is being orchestrated as a publishing event by Bloomsbury, with embargoes and coordinated release of reviews. But once we adjust our fanfare-cancelling headphones and actually sit down to read the book, we find a well-crafted, thought-provoking story about friendship—a human bond that is more complex than family ties, sex, or even politics.

The friends in question are Maryam and Zahra, women who glide effortlessly from Karachi to London and back again, each becoming a formidable public figure in her adopted country. That border-hopping is not effortless for everyone, since the UK is ever perfecting its hostile environment, and the mildest transgression gives the authorities a pretext to kick out an immigrant, trumping family connections and responsible citizenship. Shamsie has covered that ground before, but statelessness is a long-running story that any of us may star in someday. So, in *Best of Friends,* we do pay attention to what at first looks like a subplot. Two very different men are deported to Pakistan—a genial baker who gets in trouble for protecting a woman and a sleaze who enjoys frightening and shaming women. Both suffer equally disproportionate punishments, all set in motion by our double-passport expats Maryam and Zahra.

The groundwork for those incidents was laid back in Karachi, when two inseparable girls started their tenth year in school. They go to a party one evening, and the missteps and "girlfear" of one night unsettles everything in their lives. "I've always been interested, not just in friendship, but very specifically childhood friendship, which is I think quite different to adult friendship," says Shamsie. She writes about "that really intense phase of friendship", when you are adolescents. "You just want to be with your friends, with your best friend in the world. There's such an entwining of those lives and an intensity to it. And then when you're in your twenties, you discover the joy of friends who have so much in common with you. I think it's easy to not understand how important those early friendships will continue to be. Then, [it is in] your mid-forties that you realise your childhood friends connect you to your younger self."

Shamsie's story jumps ahead to that later stage when, in another country, having formed new family ties, the two women are still inseparable. Maryam, groomed as her grandfather's heir and having lost that prospect, is now a powerful businesswoman on her own account. She succeeds everywhere—her wadded up paper lands neatly in the waste-basket, her pebble skips perfectly across the water, and her patter with the prime minister achieves exactly what she aims at. She is ominously free from ethical and moral quandaries, but her personal generosity often stems from precisely that freedom. She does for Zahra what Zahra would find it impossible to do for herself.

Zahra has got ahead on her brains alone and now heads the Centre for Civil Liberties in London. She is always careful where she steps, but that doesn't keep her from sinking her expensively shod foot right in it. Coming from a more modest background, she still seeks affirmation, even from the despised. And the paths she



BEST OF FRIENDS
by Kamila Shamsie
BLOOMSBURY CIRCUS
₹599;
336 pages

The friends in question are Maryam and Zahra, women who glide effortlessly from Karachi to London and back again, each becoming a formidable public figure